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Title of the article: *Hands Up, Don't Shoot: Suicide, Black Gun Ownership, and Restoring Black Masculinity on Black Arts Movement Stages*

The content extracted is as follows:

Black activists of the 1960s and 70s advocated a cultural revolution capable of destroying institutional white racism meaning the systems of oppression that dehumanize, criminalize, exploit, and ultimately kill Black people.

He provides an early statement of this critical thought in his controversial poem, *Black Art* (1965).

Poems that wrestle cops into alleys / and take their weapons leaving them dead.² Baraka believed the Black aesthetic could galvanize the Black community to kill their oppressors and reclaim their power.

is really meaningful to us.³ Theatre also provided an important means for Black activists to urge Black audiences to take responsibility for action and justice within their communities.

Black women activists were at the forefront of this cultural revolution that was taking place on theatrical stages, reimagining the centrality of Black women's subjectivity their experiential knowledge, concerns, and desires within the framework of the Black liberation struggle.

For example, activists Sonia Sanchez, Lola E. Jones, and Carol Freeman stood among a cadre of artists-activists who used their creative talents to advocate for Black women without in any way negating concern for the collective well-being of Black families.⁴ Sanchez, Jones, and Freeman formulated new images of Black womanhood to demonstrate the complexities of Black women, their unique experiences of injustice, and the need for their ongoing leadership within Black political mobilization efforts.⁵ However, in celebrating Black women's deep commitment to the survival of Black families, Sanchez, Jones, and Freeman also issue a call for spectators to realize a more inclusive vision of Black liberation.

Sanchez recalls one instance while working in the attic of Baraka's Black Arts Repertory Theatre/School (BART/S, 1965) when a male comrade held a gun to her head and demanded that she cease writing.⁶ Despite this threat to her life, Sanchez continued to publish works that center Black women.

As a self-described revolutionary Black nationalist, Freeman's poetry and drama invoke lynching and Black women's mourning to provoke collective action.⁸ By failing to attend to the revolutionary dramas of Sanchez, Jones, and Freeman, we have lost an opportunity to elucidate the political thought of Black women artists of the Black Power era.

In this essay, I examine the discourses in Sanchez's *The Bronx Is Next* (1968), Jones's *The New Nigger, or Who's Afraid of William Faulkner* (1976), and Freeman's *The Suicide* (1966) in order to illuminate that collectively, their works demonstrate that none of us are free until all of us are free, a mantra that women leaders of the Black Lives Matter movement (2013 present) have now embraced.⁹ The second part of this essay explores the symbolic relationship among race, gender, and gun violence in four revolutionary dramas of the Black Arts Movement.

I situate their (at times) controversial dramas within Black women's long-standing activist tradition, examining how their works produce womanist thought that complicates Black Power rhetoric of self-defense and masculinist understandings of Black liberation.

By womanist, I refer to the Black feminist term coined by Alice Walker in her book, *In Search of Our Mother's Gardens: Womanist Prose* (1983).

Committed to the survival and wholeness of entire people, male and female.¹⁰ While the works of women dramatists of the Black Arts Movement pre-date Walker's Black feminist theorization; their dramas nonetheless provide an early expression of womanist thought.

In detailing how the Black Arts Movement was less uniformly masculinist than it has sometimes been depicted, I also demonstrate how Sanchez s, Jones s, and Freeman s early womanist interventions laid a critical foundation for the principles outlined by Black women activists who lead today s Black Lives Matter movement.

Arm Yourself, or Harm Yourself: Black Masculinity and the Theatre of Assault

By the 1960s, many Black activists perceived the gun as an extension of violent white patriarchy.

Baraka s founding of BART/S in 1965 turned long-standing Black political thought into action, providing a space for Black artists and activists to commune and realize the artistic vision articulated in his manifesto, *The Revolutionary Theatre* (1965).

But it is a political theatre, a weapon to help in the slaughter of these dimwitted fat-bellied white guys who somehow believe that the rest of the world is here to slobber on, writes Baraka.¹⁴ As a rhetorical weapon, revolutionary dramas functioned as a source of nourishment intended to feed Black minds heretofore starved of their own history and culture.

¹⁵ Baraka s formulations were in keeping with masculinist Black Power imagery of the time, as exemplified by the highly circulated 1967 image of Black Panther Party leader Huey P. Newton seated in a wicker chair.

Indeed, many Black activists including members of the Black Panther Party encouraged Black male gun ownership as an essential step toward reclaiming their lost manhood or kingdom.

The restoration of Black manhood which some Black Panther Party activists perceived as tantamount to the liberation of Black America entailed the ability to defend and protect the Black community from white, male-authored violence.

Their 1967 display led state politicians to pass the Mulford Act, effectively preventing Panthers from openly carrying loaded firearms during protests and copwatching patrols.¹⁶ While politicians may have curtailed their efforts, the Black Panther Party s performances of Black power inspired Black activists and offered much-needed contrast from the alltoo-familiar sight of white men leveling guns at stripped, handcuffed, and motionless Black people (fig).

Weaponless, the Black man surrenders in the same fashion as Missouri resident Michael Brown, who uttered the words *Don t shoot* before being shot and killed by Ferguson police in 2014.

Surviving, man. ¹⁸ Second Brother only wants Black people to survive white-authored shootings; he cannot envision a world wherein Black people thrive.

By hegemonic masculinity, I refer to the hierarchal power structure that uses identities such as gender, class, sexuality, age, and race in opposition to one another to empower those closest to dominant social norms while marginalizing those furthest away.¹⁹ The majority of Black men lack access to wealthy white men s political, economic, and social standing.

Unable to claim traditional markers of white-defined masculine power, Black men s use of their bodies, physicality, and a form of masculine aggressiveness becomes more important. ²⁰ Physical aggressiveness dominating Black women, boys, gay men, and poor and working-class men of other races provided a means of commanding respect, an essential aspect of Black manhood.

to be men, brother, then we deserve just what we get. ²² Second Brother considers the white officer s assault of Sister as an act of disrespect toward Black men.

Therefore taking up the gun (this power) to protect Black women becomes an important expression of Black manhood.

The phrase *Arm Yourself, or Harm Yourself*, much like today s *Hands Up, Don t Shoot*, was a rallying cry during the Black Power era.

Baraka uses this Black activist slogan as the title of his work and appends the subtitle, *A Message of Self-Defense to Black Men*, explicitly identifying Black

men as his target audience and agents of initiating armed resistance.

During the Harlem Renaissance, Black women activists such as Angelina Weld Grimke, Georgia Douglas Johnson, Mary P. Burrill, and countless others produced a body of anti-lynching plays to raise awareness and incite community action against the extrajudicial murders of Black men, women, and children.

Their efforts, and those that came before them, inspired Black women artist-activists of the Black Arts Movement, who in turn fostered a critical womanist intervention within Black Power discourse.

As Black women activists, Sanchez, Jones, and Freeman used their art to create a womanist intervention that refuted much of the masculinist Black Power rhetoric promoted by their male comrades by expanding who was included in the resistance movement.

Their efforts, and those of other Black women activists of the era, laid the groundwork for Black women to lead the Black liberation struggle of today.

We owe you and the world a debt of gratitude.²⁴ In recognizing that none of us are free until all of us are free, the Black Lives Matter movement attempts to realize its vision of centering the most marginalized voices within Black communities.

Our network centers those who have been marginalized within Black liberation movements.²⁵ Rather than perpetuate Black Power rhetoric that reduces Black liberation to the acquisition of manhood, the Black Lives Matter movement locates Black liberation at the nexus of intersectional struggle, and in so doing, creates space to revalue the sanctity of all Black lives (fig.

Guns and Bitches: Sonia Sanchez's Womanist Intervention

Sanchez's revolutionary drama *The Bronx Is Next* anticipates and actively sets the groundwork for contemporary Black (women) activists and organizers.

Along with helping organizers and student activists establish the first Black studies program in the United States, Sanchez published her first play, *The Bronx Is Next*, which premiered at Theatre Black (New York) in 1970.²⁶ *The Bronx Is Next* dramatizes the Republic of New Afrika's (1968 present) vision of establishing an independent Black nation in five US Southern states: Alabama, Georgia, Louisiana, Mississippi, and South Carolina.

According to Sanchez, the Nation of Islam had already purchased land in the South, and revolutionary leaders had begun endorsing burning down tenement houses as a way of securing livable public housing.²⁷ Elizabeth Hinton writes that securing safe and habitable public housing was a significant concern of this era, as the cycle of police violence and Black rebellion in the late 1960s and early 1970s often started in, and consumed, public housing areas.²⁸ *The Bronx Is Next* takes audiences directly to this battleground: the streets of Harlem.

And they grabbed me and told me where everything was.²⁹ Similar to the Black men in *Arm Yourself*, Jimmy describes a situation in which he found himself a potential victim of white male-authored violence (And they grabbed me and told me where everything was).

Although Black people are often socialized to behave in a submissive manner when approached by white men, smoke dulled Jimmy's sense of danger, making his behavior anything but compliant.

By asserting his manhood and staking a claim to his street (or Black communal spaces), Jimmy ran afoul with two white dudes. He does not distinguish whether they are white police officers or white vigilantes, suggesting that perhaps they are the same.

When Charles blames a difference in color for hindering Black social mobility, White Cop responds: Poverty of the mind and spirit.

He also polices the tone the Black activists use, suggesting a right and wrong way to protest shootings.

the potential threat caused by African American men's bodies.³³ Therefore the simple act of bodily movement results in white men drawing their guns.

Now fearing for his life, White Cop pleads, I m ready to stop I m tired. ³⁴ Of course, Black people are also tired of police shootings and want to eradicate all forms of white-authored violence, but this has yet to happen.

Instead, they emasculate White Cop, calling him a nigger boy as they whip him with their guns.

When Black Bitch refuses to join their trek South, Charles asserts his manhood by kissing her and declaring: I could fuck you right here if I wanted to.

³⁵ At this moment, Charles reifies hegemonic masculinity and, in so doing, maintains the structures that marginalize Black women, girls, trans, queer, and gender-nonconforming people within Black communities.

³⁶ Rather than listen to her concerns, the so-called revolutionaries beat and humiliate her, silencing her in order to clear the way for their vision of Black liberation.

authored violence can happen at any time, anywhere, for any reason. In other words, Black lives are neither valued nor protected in this country.

If you do, you die. ³⁷ Long before technology could record the dangers of running while Black, Sanchez used her craft for bearing witness to this problem.

The more recent shooting of Ahmaud Arbery serves as a stark reminder that running through the streets remains just as dangerous for Black men today as it was in 1968.

³⁸ Finally, *The Bronx Is Next* provides a warning for contemporary Black activists to beware of self-appointed white allies and those who would try to define the limits of Black liberation.

While White Cop does not utter the phrase peaceful protest, I cannot help but consider how his speech resonates with the debates I witnessed in the wake of the Black Lives Matter movement demonstrations during the summer of 2020.

I read numerous social media posts from liberal white friends, politicians, and celebrities, which all essentially stated, Police shootings are terrible, but destroying property is just as bad. These comments lead me to surmise that for some, property holds as much value as Black life.

Furthermore, Black activists must recognize the needs of the most vulnerable populations Black mothers, sex workers, and so on.

A Black Girl Shall Lead Them: Lola E. Jones s Womanist Intervention

Jones s *The New Nigger*, or *Who s Afraid of William Faulkner* also engages with Black political debates of the time, using satire to reveal the dangers of not imagining Black liberation beyond what white men define as success. In so doing, Jones reveals the absurdity of Black male bravado and makes the deadly serious argument that if Black men continue to ignore the concerns of Black women and girls, the revolution is bound to fail.

Only six Negroes were killed by whites in Mississippi last year, according to the police figures. ⁴¹ The absurdity of phrases such as things are getting better, only six Negroes were killed by whites, and police records were not lost on Black intellectuals of the time.

James Baldwin famously counterargued that one Black death at the hands of whites was too many, questioned the accuracy of police accounts, and insisted that many Southern Black men were not afraid of changing the status quo. ⁴² *The New Nigger* supports Baldwin s counterargument, demonstrating that Southern Blacks are not afraid of the world s Faulkners or white male vigilantes.

Described by Jones as a play on racism in American society, *The New Nigger* uses a play-within-a-play structure, humor, and other self-referencing devices to encourage collective action from the Black community.⁴⁴ The play opens with a violent scene of Black rebellion drawn from the imagination of a young artist named Young Black.

⁴⁵ *The New Nigger* suggests that to direct a successful revolution, Black male activists must decenter hegemonic masculinity and work with Black women and girls to strategize viable solutions to white-authored shootings.

Later, Jones reveals the fallacy of Young Black s vision of Black liberation when he performs the role of Reverend Freeman, the man responsible for leading this rebellion during The Niggers March to the Georgia state capitol building.

We aim to eat, sleep and drink where our white brother has eaten, slept and drunk for - lo - these thousand years.⁴⁸ Reverend Freeman conceptualizes Black liberation as Black men achieving the same success as white men (that is, the ability to enjoy the same leisurely activities).

⁴⁹ As a lifelong educator, Jones clearly supported educational opportunities for Black youth.

⁵⁰ Before Little s Sister s questions, Black male congregants dominated the dramatized Black nationalist debate, with Black women only occasionally interjecting Amen or other similar affirmations.

Koritha Mitchell writes, because lynching plays reflect and encourage community conversation, the emergence of the Black mother/wife as a central figure registers the degree to which her experiences informed discussions of Black identity and citizenship.⁵² Jones draws from this genre, using the typical one-act structure, the image of a devastated Black widow, the terror of a white-authored home invasion, and denial of Black citizenship to reveal the injustice of US laws.

As the conversation unfolds, audiences learn that Frank could not drive a car, yet managed to travel a far distance to commit suicide on a bridge where a thousand other Black men have also mysteriously died. Neighbor reports: Newspapers jus say he jumped, nombah some thousan jumped from the bridge, didn t hardly say much mo .⁵³ Suspicion of foul play intensifies when Wife reveals that Frank was raily a good man, cept readin o-all them books, and drankin so much wine done rumn him crazy.⁵⁴ Frank s intelligence and alcohol use likely lowered his inhibitions, making him more outspoken and therefore a target for white male violence.

From its position of authority, the Black Church has shown strong support for the patriarchal family, claiming that men should be the heads of the church, that women should not be preachers, and that men should rule their families, writes Collins.⁵⁶ Jones s apolitical Preacher embodies this popular conservative politics, caring more for the appearance of respectability than for galvanizing the Black community to agitate for social justice.

Had he moved beyond voyeurism and fulfilled his Christian duty, Preacher might have helped her put together the suspicious circumstances of Frank s supposed suicide. However, as a voyeur of Black trauma porn, Preacher says nothing to alleviate Wife s suffering and does nothing to incite justice.

The officers invasion of Wife s home reflects the painful reality that Black women have never been safe inside their own homes.⁵⁸ The officers embody a sadistic joy in terrorizing Wife in her home, a morbid tradition which traces back to the Jim Crow era.⁵⁹ When the officers open Frank s coffin against Wife s wishes and she demands they close the coffin to prevent flies from eating his body, Second Cop handles her roughly and hauls her off to jail for resisting arrest. Wife s experience of loss, assault, and unwarranted arrest compounded by Preacher s inaction reinforces Malcolm X s famous 1962 speech in which he declared: the most disrespected person in America is the Black woman.⁶⁰ Indeed, in the course of a single day, Wife has lost her husband, witnessed no justice for his murder, been prevented from mourning him, and lost her rights of citizenship as she joins the prison population.

Regardless of the answer, Frank s murder reflects a grim reality: we will never know what actually happened to thousands of Black men and women activists who were murdered or simply vanished during the Jim Crow and civil rights eras.

The revolutionary spirit of The Suicide resonated with the political impulses of Black student activists at Northwestern University.

The Suicide premiered at Black Folks s Theatre, the artistic branch of the Black student union aptly named For Members Only, in 1971.⁶¹ Inspired by Teer s theories of performance, Black Folks s Theatre members defined themselves as liberators who used theatre to educate, heal, and galvanize the Black Chicagoland community.⁶² Student activists realized their vision in 1971 with The Black Portrait, an event that included productions of The Suicide, Sanchez s Sister Son/ji (1969), and Jimmy Garrett s We Own the Night (1968).

The summer of 2020, in particular, invoked the memory of Billie Holiday's Black protest song *Strange Fruit* (1939).

But family members of the deceased, protestors and activists, and some scholars of anti-Black violence are intuitively suspicious about those conclusions, writes journalist Stacey Patton.⁶⁴ Harsch's sister, for example, remains suspicious of the suicide ruling.

Someone took their time with that knot, explains Harmonie Harsch.⁶⁵ In addition to the skepticism of Harsch, Black activists and scholars also remain doubtful of the ruling, in part because Black suicides are often misclassified.⁶⁶ Psychologists Alex Crosby and Sherry Davis Molock write: By this definition, an alarmingly high number of Black homicides are brought on by behaviors that create their own death.

Unfortunately, behaviors deemed risky for Black people, such as jogging, are everyday leisure activities for most other communities.

Conclusion

For this reason, I urge Black artists and activists to answer Charlene Carruthers's call to embrace Black queer feminist praxis as a tool of empowerment.

Founded upon the theories and practices of Black feminist and LGBTQ+ activists, Black queer feminist praxis fosters the liberation of all Black people, regardless of gender, sexuality, age, class, and so forth by allowing people and groups to bring their full selves into the process of dismantling all systems of oppression.⁶⁹ Carruthers writes that by using this lens, we can more effectively prioritize problems and methods that center historically marginalized people in our communities.⁷⁰ As the revolutionary theatre of the Black Arts Movement can attest, the theatre has served as a powerful tool to disseminate such calls.

We must do more to support the efforts of Black artists and activists who answer this call today.

Analyzing the more recent past serves as an important reminder that many of the gains made by Black activists and their allies have been systematically dismantled following the Black Power era.

Black activists and their allies also fought to put Black history and culture back on the world stage, creating the first Black studies program at San Francisco State College in 1968.

Unfortunately, the practice got co-opted, exemplified by the fact that today, Black studies courses reside behind the gates of the ivory tower, firmly out of reach for many Black people.⁷¹ The erosion of civil rights protections, coupled with the ever-present threat of white male-authored shootings, attests to the urgent need to foster Black art and activism at every level of society.

The energy that fuels anti-Black violence has never gone away, because in all situations to hearken to the sentiments of Patricia Young the perpetrators saw themselves as agents to their white peers.⁷² They were confident that as executioners of justice, they would avoid any accountability for their actions.

We have lost generations of Black artists and activists to the everyday, less-sensationalized occurrence of white-authored shootings.

Their premature deaths have had a profound impact on the lives of many, myself included. Having survived abject poverty and gun violence in one of the wealthiest countries in the world, I now ask: How can Black activists and their allies use theatre as a tool to further Black liberation?

I hope that twenty-first-century Black activists and their allies will learn from these efforts and create art that engages the masses and fosters the inclusive aims of the Black Lives Matter movement.